

[Anushka Shendge]

[CSE-AIML]

Company: Nomura

Job Profile: CDO (Data Engineer/ Data Science Analyst)

Offer Type: [Internship Only / Placement Only / Internship + Placement]

Internship Stipend: 75000

CTC:13.66 (2L signing Bonus + 11.66 Base)

Location: Powai - Mumbai

Process Date: 28 July PPT - 31 July OA - 1 August Interview

“Sometimes, what feels like a rejection is just redirection — every 'no' I faced made me sharper for the 'yes' that finally mattered”

Placements are as much about **perseverance and mindset** as they are about **skills and preparation**.

Despite being confident in my technical knowledge, I faced **rejections in the HR rounds of PhonePe and MSCI**. These moments were tough — not because I wasn't capable, but because **luck plays a huge role** in the process, often more than we like to admit.

Still, I chose not to give up. Every interview, even the ones that didn't go as planned, was a learning opportunity that prepared me for what came next.

Placement Process:

FOR CDO

1. Pre-placement Talk

2. OA

3. Technical Interview 1

5. HR Round

1. IOA [200]

The first round was an **Online Assessment**, which consisted of **three sections**:

- **Analytical Reasoning**
 - **Quantitative Aptitude**
 - **Verbal Ability**
- Total Duration:** 60 minutes

Verbal Section

*This section included **reading comprehension passages** and **sentence correction/fill-in-the-blank** type questions.*

*The questions were **pretty straightforward** and easy to handle with a decent understanding of grammar and reading speed.*

Quantitative Section

*The quants questions were **moderately easy** — covering basic math concepts.*

*However, the **Data Interpretation (DI)** problems required more time and could become time-consuming **if not planned properly**.*

A good strategy is key to managing this section effectively.

Preparation Note:

*I hadn't done a lot of dedicated practice before this round, but I found that **IndiaBix** was a really good platform to brush up on **Aptitude and Verbal topics**.*

If you're preparing for such rounds, I'd recommend giving it a go.

SHORTLISTING FOR CDO WAS BASED ON OA AND RESUME

2. [Tech Interview] [8-CDO, 28-ITD, 19-GM]

I was interviewed for the **Chief Data Officer (CDO)** role, and there were **two interviewers** taking the interview simultaneously. The conversation began with a simple **"Introduce yourself"** question.

As they went through my resume, they noticed that I had done a lot of **hackathons and development-focused projects**. Since the role was related more to **data analysis**, they asked me about my **interest in the role** and whether I'd be comfortable switching gears from development.

I answered honestly. I mentioned that while my journey started from the development side and I naturally feel inclined toward it, I've also worked on projects that align with data roles and would be **comfortable and interested** in this direction as well.

Project Discussion

They asked me to explain **two ML-related projects**:

1. Rapid Compliance Checker (RAG-based)

I explained the **RAG (Retrieval Augmented Generation)** architecture used in this project.

They asked a follow-up: *"RAG gives k results. What if only 1 is relevant and the rest are not?"*

I answered by talking about an **optimized approach using Graph RAG**, which helps improve contextual relevance and filter better responses using semantic relationships.

2. Voice Automation Platform

This project included a **smart suggestion engine** which detects tasks and offers to perform them. The suggestions were based on **Gemini**.

They grilled me a bit here — especially about **how Gemini handles sensitive or inappropriate language**.

For example, they asked what would happen if someone asked Gemini to send a **bad word/abusive message**.

I replied that **Gemini won't acknowledge such prompts**, but in case it does, we can **fine-tune** the model or even **build a custom LLM** to avoid that.

They mentioned the **cost of fine-tuning**, so I proposed a lighter solution — **prompt-level checks** to prevent such actions rather than acknowledge them.

DSA Question

They asked me if I was comfortable with **Python**, to which I said yes.

Question:

Group the anagrams from the list:

`["abc", "cba", "tea", "eat", "pig", "gpi", "pay"]`

I was able to solve it immediately — and instead of using a dictionary (map), I used a **26-sized array** for each word.

When asked why, I explained that it avoids **extra space overhead**, while maintaining the **same time complexity**.

System Design: ATS Scanner

Next, I was asked to design an **ATS (Applicant Tracking System) Scanner** that could fetch the **5 most relevant resumes for an SDE role**.

I drew the **RAG-based architecture** again, explaining each step:

- **Document Retrieval**
- **Chunking resumes**
- **Vector embedding and storing**
- **Extracting keywords from the job description** (like expected technologies and tools)

They asked how I would extract these keywords. I gave an example using **Nomura's JD**, which had a **"Technologies we expect"** section. I mentioned we can **automate the extraction using LLMs**.

SQL Questions

They gave me a **complex SQL query involving DENSE_RANK**. I was able to understand and write the query within **2 minutes**. They seemed quite impressed and also appreciated that I clarified the question properly before answering.

<https://leetcode.com/problems/department-top-three-salaries/description/?envType=study-plan-v2&envId=top-sql-50> (SIMILAR TO THIS)

They then asked about **joins**. They gave me two tables and asked to find the output for each type of join.

Table 1:

id

1

1

1

1

5

Table 2:

id

1

2

3

4

5

Though it was a bit tricky, I managed to answer **all join variations correctly**.

Closing Conversation

By now, the atmosphere was quite friendly. They asked me about where I stay, how I commute to college, and we had a light conversation about the company.

At the end, they asked if I had any questions.

I asked:

"How do you ensure the authenticity of data when it's coming from multiple sources?"

We had a small discussion on that, and then the interview was wrapped up.

Overall, it was a **friendly and engaging experience** where I got to talk about both my development and data-related work. I appreciated the depth of their questions and the interest they showed in my answers.

3. [HR] [2- CDO]

I was the first one to be called for the HR round. The conversation was very casual and felt more like a normal chat than a formal interview.

The HR asked me about:

- My family background
- Where I stay
- My personal goals and aspirations

It lasted around 10–15 minutes, and nothing too technical or intense came up.

But here's where things took an unexpected turn.

A Twist After the HR Round

After the round ended, the HR simply told me,
“Your process for today is over, you can go home now.”

I was **shocked and confused**. Usually, candidates are asked to wait or are given further instructions. So, I went to the **placement coordinator** and asked what this meant.

They quietly told me,
“This usually means you're not selected.”

I was genuinely **sad and disappointed** and left the campus thinking I hadn't made it.

But then — after some time — the **final HR result list came out**, and **my name was in it!**

Turns out, it was a **bit of a prank or a surprise moment** — and I was actually **selected**.

2 STUDENTS WERE OFFERED THE ROLE I WAS ONE OF THEM

Useful Tips:

1. Stay calm and confident during the interviews. The interviewers are quite friendly so be vocal about the approaches that you are using.
2. Always be aware of each and every point that you have mentioned on your resume.
3. Practice questions on a daily basis to stay in touch. Try CP as well as it helps in logic building and improves problem solving skills.
4. For aptitude, IndiaBix is good.

5. Take core subjects seriously.

Resources:

1. DSA - <https://takeuforward.org/strivers-a2z-dsa-course/strivers-a2z-dsa-course-sheet-2>

2. OS - https://youtu.be/8XBtAjKwCm4?si=p_ULjiv7pJM0ec6u

3. CCN - <https://youtu.be/IPvYjXCSTg8?si=abE42qC1m3HIY6tC>

4. OOPS / JAVA - https://youtu.be/BSVKUk58K6U?si=QI9wD1B_Pl2i3eLW

5. DBMS - refer Gate Smasher / Chatgpt

ALL THE BEST guys!!!!

You can reach out to me on [Linkedin](#) for any queries.